

Singapore–Cambridge GCE O Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) Paper 2 — Comprehension Practice Paper 17

Time allowed: 1 hour 50 minutes

Total marks for Sections B and C: 45

Instructions to candidates

- Answer **all** questions in Sections B and C.
- The number of marks is given in brackets [] at the end of each question.
- Answer in **complete sentences** where instructed.
- For the summary in Section C, write **no more than 80 words**, not counting the words given to help you begin.

Section B — Text 3 (Narrative) [20 marks]

Text 3: The narrator drives his elderly mother to the airport for a long-haul flight to visit relatives overseas — a journey both of them suspect may be her last.

1

She had been packing for three weeks. By the morning of the flight, the small green suitcase that had once carried her through forty years of her own travelling sat by the front door like a patient, well-behaved animal, its zip pulled tight and its handle wrapped, with quiet ceremony, in a strip of pink ribbon. The ribbon had not been my idea. She had asked me to tie it on so that she could pick out her bag at the carousel in Sydney, and the request, modest as it was, had unsettled me more than I cared to admit.

2

I had offered, weeks earlier, to drive her. She had refused twice — pleasantly, the way she refused everything she wanted you to insist on — and then, on the third asking, had agreed. We left at half past five in the morning. The sky over the estate was a soft, undecided grey, the colour of a thing not yet certain whether to be light or dark, and the road, normally so loud, was almost empty. In the passenger seat, my mother sat very straight, her handbag balanced on her knees as though it were a small, frightened pet.

3

“You have your passport?” I asked, for the third time. She patted the handbag without looking down. “And the boarding pass print-out? The doctor’s letter for the medication?” Another pat, another small, patient smile. I knew that she had checked these things eleven times the night before, and that asking again was, in some way, an insult. But I could not stop myself. The questions were not really questions. They were a way of keeping my hands busy when I could not hold hers.

4

Halfway along the expressway, the argument began. It was not, in any real sense, an argument. She wanted me to take the older coastal route. I wanted the tunnel. The tunnel was faster, I told her; she

would have more time at the gate. She looked out of the window and said, very quietly, that she had always liked the coastal road, and that one did not, after all, get many more chances to see the sea from a car at six in the morning. I drove, without speaking, to the next exit, and turned off. I did not trust my voice to say anything sensible. The sea, when we reached it, was the colour of beaten tin, and she watched it with the open, undemanding attention of a child.

5

At the terminal, I unloaded the suitcase. It was, in the end, absurdly light — she had packed only what she could lift herself, despite my having begged her, repeatedly, to let me handle the heavy things. There was a folder in her handbag containing the address of my aunt in Sydney, written out three times in three different inks, in case one copy went missing. There were boiled sweets. There was a small, sealed envelope addressed to my father, who had been dead for nine years, which she had asked me, the night before, to keep “somewhere safe” until she came home. I had said yes. I had not asked.

6

We stood at the kerb. She was wearing her good blue cardigan, and her hair, freshly set the day before, had not yet lost its careful shape. She looked, in that pale morning light, much smaller than I remembered her being. I had been taller than her since the age of fourteen. I had never, until that morning, properly noticed how thin her wrists had become, or how the gold watch I had given her for her seventieth birthday now slipped, every few minutes, halfway down her forearm. She caught me looking and tugged the watch back into place with a small, embarrassed laugh.

7

“Call me when you land,” I said.

“Of course.”

“Eat on the plane. Don’t be polite about it.”

“Of course.”

There were a hundred other things. There was the matter of her tablets, which she sometimes forgot at lunchtime; there was the matter of the cold in Sydney in May, which she always underestimated; there was the matter, larger than either of these, that I did not know, and could not bring myself to ask, whether she would come back to me as the same woman who was leaving. I said none of these things. I hugged her, briefly, the way grown men hug their mothers at airports, and I felt her hand at the back of my neck — the same hand, exactly the same hand, that had pulled my collar straight on the first day of primary school.

8

Then she went, with her green suitcase and its pink ribbon, through the sliding doors. I stood for a long time on the kerb after she had disappeared, holding the parking ticket in one hand and, in the other, the small sealed envelope she had, at the last moment, pressed back into my palm. I did not open it. I do not think I ever will.

From Paragraph 1

1. The suitcase sat by the front door “like a patient, well-behaved animal.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison suggests about the suitcase. [2]

2. Why was the narrator “unsettled” by his mother’s request to tie a ribbon on the suitcase? Suggest one possible reason. [1]

From Paragraph 2

3. The narrator says that his mother “refused twice — pleasantly, the way she refused everything she wanted you to insist on.” What does this tell us about her **character**? [2]

4. The handbag on his mother’s knees is described as being like “a small, frightened pet.” What does this comparison suggest about his mother at this moment? [2]

From Paragraph 3

5. The narrator writes: “The questions were not really questions. They were a way of keeping my hands busy when I could not hold hers.”

(a) What does this tell us about why he kept repeating the same questions? [1]

(b) What does it suggest about how he feels towards his mother but cannot easily express? [1]

From Paragraph 4

6. Explain how the language in Paragraph 4 shows that the disagreement about the route is **not really about the route**. Support your answer with **two** details from the paragraph. [3]

From Paragraph 5

7. Give **two** details from Paragraph 5 that suggest the mother is anxious about the journey, despite appearing calm. [2]

8. What is the effect of the writer’s use of **dashes** in the phrase “a small, sealed envelope addressed to my father, who had been dead for nine years”? [1]

From Paragraph 6

9. The narrator says his mother “looked, in that pale morning light, much smaller than I remembered her being.” What does this suggest about how the narrator is now seeing his mother? [2]

From Paragraph 7

10. The narrator says that he felt his mother’s hand at the back of his neck — “the same hand, exactly the same hand, that had pulled my collar straight on the first day of primary school.” Explain the **effect** of repeating the phrase “the same hand.” [2]

From Paragraph 8

11. What is the **tone** of the final sentence of the text? [1]

Section C — Text 4 (Non-narrative) [25 marks]

Text 4: A feature article examining why so many young adults across the world are still living with their parents well into their twenties and thirties.

1

A generation ago, leaving the family home in one's early twenties was treated, in much of the Western world, as a kind of secular rite of passage. One finished one's studies, packed a single battered suitcase, and rented a flat with strangers; one did not, except in the case of illness or disaster, move back. Today, that script has quietly fallen apart. In the United States, more than half of all adults aged eighteen to twenty-nine now live with at least one parent — the highest figure since records began in the 1940s. In Italy, the proportion is approaching two-thirds. Even in Britain, traditionally a culture of early departure, the average age of leaving home has crept past twenty-four. The “boomerang generation”, once a tabloid curiosity, has become, in many countries, simply the generation.

2

The first and most obvious explanation is economic. Housing, in nearly every major city in the developed world, has grown astonishingly more expensive relative to wages. A 2023 study by the OECD found that the price of an average home in member countries had risen, in real terms, by 37 per cent since 2010, while real wages for workers under thirty had risen by only 4 per cent. Rents, in cities such as London, Sydney and Vancouver, now routinely consume more than half of a young worker's take-home pay. A young person with a degree, a salary and a clean record can quite reasonably do the sums and conclude that staying in the spare bedroom is the only mathematically honest option.

3

Yet to attribute the trend entirely to money is to miss something. Cultural attitudes have shifted in step with prices. Parents who themselves grew up in stricter, more independence-prizing households are, on the whole, less inclined to push their children out. A 2022 Pew Research survey found that 72 per cent of American parents of adult children said they would be “happy” or “very happy” for those children to remain at home indefinitely, provided the relationship was respectful — a figure that would have struck their own parents as eccentric. Family, in short, has become a softer, less hierarchical thing, and the threshold for “overstaying” has correspondingly risen.

4

In much of Asia, of course, the story looks different. In Singapore, in South Korea, in large parts of China and India, multigenerational living was never a sign of failure; it was simply how families lived. The interesting question in these societies is not why so many young adults stay, but why a small but growing number now wish to leave — and how that wish is being read by the older generation as a worrying sign of imported individualism. The same arrangement, in other words, that is celebrated in Milan as “family closeness” is occasionally lamented in Seoul as “delayed adulthood”. Geography, it turns out, decides which of those labels gets attached.

5

The consequences for mental health are mixed, and the research is more nuanced than headlines suggest. On the one hand, a 2021 meta-analysis of studies across fourteen countries found that young adults living with supportive parents reported, on average, lower rates of loneliness and modestly better sleep than peers in shared rentals. On the other hand, the same analysis flagged a striking minority — about one in five — who reported feelings of “developmental stagnation”: a sense that life had been paused, that important markers of adulthood (a relationship, a career risk, even a quiet morning) were harder to claim under a parent's roof. The arrangement, it seems, helps most when it is **chosen**, and harms most when it is endured.

6

There are knock-on effects for cities, too. Town planners, accustomed to designing flats for couples and small families, are quietly waking up to the fact that the household of the near future may often contain three adult generations under one roof. Demand for “multi-key” apartments — units with two front doors and a shared kitchen — has risen sharply in Singapore and Tokyo. Builders in Sydney are advertising “granny flats” not to grannies but to grown-up sons. Meanwhile, the markets that used to depend on young renters — the corner cafe, the cheap furniture chain, the first-flat IKEA pilgrimage — are having to rethink their assumptions about who, in any given year, is leaving home and who is staying.

7

What, then, are families to make of all this? Perhaps the kindest reading is that we are returning, slowly and a little awkwardly, to an older model: one in which adult children and ageing parents share a roof, share a kitchen, and, with patience, share the labour of looking after each other. The harshest reading is that an entire generation has been priced out of the independence its parents took for granted, and is now being asked to call its captivity by softer names. Both readings, uncomfortably, are partly true. What seems clear is that the question is no longer whether young adults will continue to live with their parents — many evidently will — but whether the families, the homes, and the cities they inhabit are ready to be honest about it.

From Paragraph 1

12. The writer says that leaving the family home was once “a kind of secular rite of passage.” Explain, in your own words, what this phrase suggests about how earlier generations viewed leaving home. [2]

13. At the end of Paragraph 1, the writer says that the “boomerang generation” has “become, in many countries, simply the generation.” Explain what the writer means by this. [2]

From Paragraph 2

14. According to Paragraph 2, give **two** economic reasons why young adults find it difficult to move out. [2]

15. The writer says that staying at home is “the only mathematically honest option.” What is the writer’s **attitude** towards young adults who choose to stay at home? [1]

From Paragraph 3

16. The writer says that the figure of 72 per cent “would have struck their own parents as eccentric.” Explain, in your own words, what this comparison tells us about how attitudes have changed across generations. [2]

From Paragraph 4

17. In Paragraph 4, the writer says: “The same arrangement... that is celebrated in Milan as ‘family closeness’ is occasionally lamented in Seoul as ‘delayed adulthood’”

(a) What is the purpose of the **inverted commas** around “family closeness” and “delayed adulthood”? [1]

(b) What is the writer trying to suggest by **contrasting** Milan and Seoul in this way? [2]

From Paragraph 5

18. The writer says of young adults living at home: “The arrangement, it seems, helps most when it is **chosen**, and harms most when it is endured.” Explain, in your own words, what this means. [2]

From Paragraph 6

19. Give **two** details from Paragraph 6 that show how cities are **adapting** to the trend of young adults living with parents. [2]

From Paragraph 7

20. The writer offers a “kindest reading” and a “harshesht reading” of the trend. What is the writer’s **purpose** in offering both readings rather than choosing one? [2]

21. What is the **tone** of the phrase “is now being asked to call its captivity by softer names”? [1]

22. Summary question [6 marks for content, 7 marks for use of own words and style]

Using your own words as far as possible, summarise **the reasons why so many young adults still live with their parents**, and **the consequences of this trend for individuals and for cities**, as outlined in the text.

Use **only** material from **Paragraphs 2 to 6** of Text 4.

Your summary must be in **continuous writing** (not note form). It must **not** be longer than **80 words** (not counting the words given to help you begin).

Begin your summary as follows:

Many young adults remain in the family home partly because ...

— END OF PAPER —